

AGARAGA

AFTER HISTORIC HAUL, BIGGER TESTS AWAIT

After its **most successful campaign** at the Asian Boxing Championships in two decades, the Indian women's boxing team now turns its attention to the Commonwealth and Asian Games.

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Not long after her return to India from the Asian Boxing Championships in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, where she won gold in the women's 54kg category, Preeti Pawar (**facing page, below**) told *Sportstar* how she was looking forward to spending time with her family in the boxing town of Bhiwani in Haryana.

"For the last three months before the Asian Championships, I was in the national camp. All the girls were missing *ghar ka khana* (home-cooked meals). I'm looking forward to eating my mother's *roti, churma* and *halwa*. I can enjoy that food a little bit now," the 22-year-old said.

The treats are well deserved. Preeti had a spectacular tournament in Ulaanbaatar, beating two Olympic medallists — Korea's Im Aeji and Taiwan's Huang Hsiao-wen — to win her first continental championship.

But Preeti is clear that while she'll savour, she won't really indulge. Her mind is already preparing for the next national camp, which will begin in Patiala in the last week of April. "I know that I only have a few days at home. After that, I have to get into the same mindset of competition. I've done well at the Asian Championships, but now I will be preparing for the Commonwealth and Asian Games. There will be a lot of expectations on me there," she says.

Great expectations

In Mongolia, every single member of the women's team finished on the podium — 10 medals in all, including four gold, two silver and four bronze. The result was Indian women's boxing's best (in terms of medal count) at the Asian Championships in over two decades. The men settled for six overall, with one gold.

Coach Santiago Nieva says the result was even better than what he had been hoping for. "We had pretty high expectations going in, considering we already had two boxers who had won world championship gold last year [Jaismine Lamboriya in the women's 57kg category and Meenakshi Hooda in the

Power play: Arundhati Choudhary (70kg) was one of four gold medallists in the women's team, alongside Minakshi Hooda (48kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg), and Priya Ghanghas (60kg). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT